

THE FATHERLAND IN MARBLE

The Viareggio Literary Prize has been subjected this year to much justified criticism. The most striking peculiarity was its being cut into twelve portions, revealing, to say the least, a considerable amount of dissension and uncertainty among the judges. We should recall, however, that even normally the prize is divided into four categories: fiction, poetry, "first published work," and non-fictional literature. One of the books which received a third of the prize in this category seems to have gathered a solid consensus of opinion: *La patria di marmo*, by Marcello Venturoli, (Pisa Nistri-Lischi, 1957). It is in some ways a unique book: a slice of modern Italian life centering on the biography of a monument. The "fatherland in marble" of the title is the monument to Victor Emmanuel II, known in official parlance as the "altar of the fatherland," aesthetically the mootest structure in Rome.

Venturoli's book is far from being simply a history of the monument from the time when, shortly after the unification of Italy, the possibility of erecting such an architectural emblem was conceived, to the day of its official inauguration (though it was still unfinished) in 1911; nor is it simply, or even predominantly, a biography of its major artifex, Count Giuseppe Sacconi, who devoted practically his whole life and energies to this single work. The thread

provided by Sacconi's life and by the vicissitudes of the building is continuously and intentionally lost in the wide canvas of a work which, in 500 large pages of thick print, spans the last quarter of the past century and the first decade of our own. It touches on all aspects of national life, from politics to fashions, from colonial war to financial scandals, from royal visits (the Tsar, Edward VII, the Kaiser) to class struggle and general strikes. If the book has a major theme, however undeclared, it is a rather obvious one: the contrast between an official, "marble" image of the *patria* and the fluid landscape of national life in all its variety. In the long years during which the monument grew, this theme may have frequently emerged in terms of open and articulate conflict: the conflict between a practical, "non-poetic" concept of the nation's problems and necessities as they were often preached for instance by exponents of the Socialist Party, and that taste for the glorious gesture and the symbolism of patriotism which found some of its outlets in a part of d'Annunzio's work, or in the activities of the Nationalist Party. Such contrasts are known also elsewhere, but in Italy they were probably felt with greater urgency, as when Giuseppe Prezzolini wrote in 1910: "Nationalism is much more dangerous for us because with its vagueness and magniloquent imprecision it is above all likely to furnish ma-

terial for our rhetorical inclinations, and distract thought from those practical problems and precise interests which had begun to preoccupy the Italian people, and without solving which, they will never be a Nation." (Quoted on p. 461, from the review *La voce*.)

It is difficult to suggest the variety of information, of interesting insights into the life of the period, of revealing episodes and vignettes that this book contains. To choose at random among the "lighter" items: the triumphant reception of Buffalo Bill in Rome (p. 101); Verdi's telegram on being offered the title of Marquis of Busseto, ending: "This does not exclude my gratitude which will be much greater if nomination cancelled" (p. 133); d'Annunzio's famous *coup de théâtre* while a member of Parliament, walking ostentatiously from a seat on the Right to one on the Left ("I go toward Life;" p. 191); young King Victor Emmanuel III watching "with his customary, dignified secretiveness" a parade of fifty automobiles in May 1902, flanked by two army majors who were entrusted by the War Ministry to study the importance of the new means of transportation (p. 212); the fall of the campanile of St. Mark in Venice, with no casualties, an event which had international repercussions among Venice-lovers (14 July 1902; p. 235, and the whole chapter, *passim*); Italian repercussions of the Russian revolt of 1905, with

Giacomo Puccini, Antonio Fogazzaro, and others, uniting in public protest against the arrest of Maxim Gorki (p. 338); the opening, in a Rome theatre, in January 1908, of d'Annunzio's milestone in the history of patriotic aestheticism, the verse play *La nave*, when even the official organ of the Socialist Party was "caught by an inferiority complex" and praised it (p. 415); the reception given to two Italian heroes of an automobile race from Peking to Paris, Prince Borghese and the journalist Barzini, who were greeted, on arriving in the French capital, with the march from *Aida*.

All countries, to be sure, possess official monuments which are not usually praised as great works of art; and the Victor Emmanuel monument in Rome may be an extreme case also on account of its size and location. Minor as the consolation may be to those who aesthetically detest it, Venturoli's book relates in detail how it came about; on the artistic history (projects, choice of materials, relationship between Sacconi and sculptors, etc.) and on the administrative history (parliamentary debates, royal committees, etc.) his research has been painstaking and its results can be regarded as definitive; we may not like the final product, but it is a sort of relief to have it "explained". To give the supremely obvious instance, on page 77 and ff., Venturoli by telling the story of the selection of *botticino* as the particular type

of marble used, gives some sort of justification for the famous and universally deplored "caddaverous white" of the monument. Yet, to summarize, the main value of the book is in the immersion which it permits into a period of Italian life not as widely explored as its great interest might warrant. Italian history has always been quite peculiar; the period immediately following Italy's appearance on the world stage as a unified and "modern" country is, both for positive and for negative reasons, among the most fascinating. Here we are reminded of some of the period's significant events and of many of its major and minor characters. Incidentally, and to end on a pedantic note, Italian typography could have done better with the illustrations, extremely well-chosen and interesting as they are; and an Index of Names would have been welcome. [P. M. P.]

THE MAESTRO

As a light informal biography of Arturo Toscanini, *The Magic Baton* (New York: G. P. Putnam's Sons, 1957) by Filippo Sacchi is well conceived and well composed. It sketches, incisively and authoritatively, the trajectory of his public career from the momentous night in Rio de Janeiro when at the age of nineteen he mounted the podium and conducted the whole of *Aida*, to the last days in Riverdale when at the age of eighty-nine he was editing just before his

death his recorded performance of *Aida*. Though it is quite properly the story of extraordinary talent, luck, and implacable will, it is also an historical evocation of the cultural past. Our memory of Toscanini is still so fresh that we may be inadvertently surprised at recalling that his eminence at La Scala dates from 1898 and that by 1908 he, an Italian, had commanded a free hand at the utterly Teutonic Metropolitan. Indeed, when he began to conduct opera, the manners and attitudes he eventually succeeded in remolding (the obsessive and irrelevant social associations of opera, the tyranny of the public and the *prime donne*, the operatic tradition of Bellini and his epigones) were the direct inheritance of the late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries.

Inevitably, Mr. Sacchi intrigues his reader with bits of social history, which are properly subordinated in context, but which resound more authentically than the actual character of his subject (a friend, a figure recently dead and therefore venerable) whose full lineaments cannot be traced at this short distance in history. One is grateful for the evocation of nineteenth-century Parma, for the characterization of Toscanini's passionately *garibaldino* father, and for the whole life of music in those days, marginally but vividly suggested. Layers are properly distinguished: the age of Bellini and Stendhal, the complacency and then the revolu-

tion of the middle of the century, imported "diabolism", and the emergence of a new age: "Even Boito—the Boito whom we have all known, old, loaded with honours, senator, president of academies, ornament of aristocratic salons—had taken hashish in his youth." We may be moved by Toscanini's devotion to his friend, the fated Catalani; we may also marvel, in a mingling of amusement and pathos, at how sharply the libretto of his *Edmea* evokes the age. "Edmea is a sort of Ophelia of the Elbe. When the brave Oberto departs she is forced by his father to marry Ulmo. She throws herself into the river and, when fished out by her husband, is found to have gone mad and wanders around, dressed like a fantastic water-fairy, until the end, when she falls into the arms of the inconsolable Oberto and recovers her reason; poor Ulmo poisons himself to allow them to marry, begging Edmea for the supreme gift of a kiss on the forehead; not at once—that would be asking too much—but after his death."

Yet the true subject is Toscanini the great conductor. The reader will be fascinated by the glimpses of complexity in the character of the lower-class musician from Parma: his deep sympathy for Catalani and the eccentric painter Grubicy, his espousal and conflict with the post-Verdian school as represented antithetically by Puccini and Pizzetti, his embarrassed support of the early

socialist Mussolini and his later resistance to fascism, and generally his unflinching refusal to tolerate sloth, failure, unprincipled behavior, and stupidity. He was both an innovator and a traditionalist, a harsh disciplinarian and a selfless servant of music, a family man and a philanderer. An intimate revelation of the book is his tender solicitude for his natural son by Rosina Storchio, who after having lived "completely palsied and speechless", died at the age of sixteen. When the time is ripe, Mr. Sacchi's memoir will be one of the cornerstones of the eventual definitive biography.

[L. N.]

THE INCOMPARABLE GADDA

The most important fictional work of the season, indeed perhaps of the year, has come from a writer of the older generation, Carlo Emilio Gadda, born in 1893, or more exactly, as he puts it, fourteen days before the fall of the first Giolitti cabinet. He was better known, until now at least, in highly literate circles than among the ordinary fiction-reading public, difficult as that public may be to identify as a class, especially in Italy. This time, the support of a publisher whose commercial acumen is a trademark may have helped Gadda considerably; it remains to be seen whether his conquest of a wider public is a permanent one.

The novel confronts us, in a more emphatic form than pos-